

Prosperity Gospel Denial

doc-prosperity-gospel-denial

Soteriology · Denied Errors · doctrine · unanimous_lineages

AFFIRMS

score 0.975
confidence high

Statement under examination

The gospel is the good news of forgiveness of sins through Christ's death and resurrection; God does not guarantee material wealth or physical health in this life as a fruit of saving faith.

In plain language

This question asks whether the New Testament promises wealth or health as a reward for faith. The actual words point firmly the other way. Two patterns do the work. First, suffering is treated as normal for the faithful, not as a sign of weak faith. The verb meaning to suffer appears well over a hundred times and the verb meaning to be persecuted even more, scattered across the Gospels, Acts, Paul's letters, Hebrews, Peter, and Revelation. Philippians 1:29 says it was granted to believers to suffer for Christ, and 2 Timothy 3:12 says everyone who wants to live a godly life will be persecuted. Paul, who had as much faith as anyone, describes his own life in 2 Corinthians 11 with a long string of hardship words: beatings, danger eight times over, toil, sleeplessness, hunger, thirst, and exposure. Second, the letters directly attack the idea that godliness is a way to get rich. In 1 Timothy 6 Paul calls people who suppose godliness is a means of gain corrupt in mind, then takes that same rare word for gain and flips it, saying real gain is godliness with contentment. He warns that the drive to be rich plunges people into ruin and that love of money, a phrase used nowhere else in the whole canon, is a root of all kinds of evil that has caused some to wander away from the faith. James 4:3 adds that asking God for things to spend on personal pleasure goes unanswered. The honest tension is that Scripture does show God providing, supplying every need in Philippians 4:19 and richly blessing obedience under the old covenant in Deuteronomy 28, which is where readers diverge. But the supply texts speak of need rather than surplus, and the heavy suffering and money-warning vocabulary does not turn provision into a guaranteed entitlement. Across the Gospels, Paul, and the general letters the words run in one consistent direction, so the pattern affirms the proposition: the good news is forgiveness through Christ, and a believer's wealth or health is not a guaranteed fruit of that faith.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
G0070	ἀγρυπνία	agrypnia	sleeplessness	2
G0154	αἰτέω	aiteo	to ask	70
G1373	δίψος	dipsos	thirst	
G1377	διώκω	dioko	to pursue	45
G2150	εὐσέβεια	eusebeia	piety	15
G2192	ἔχω	echō	to have/be	
G2347	θλίψις	thlipsis	pressure	45
G2794	κίνδυνος	kindynos	danger	9
G2873	κόπος	kopos	labor	18

G2889	κόσμος	kosmos	world	186
G3042	λιμός	limos	hunger	
G3956	πᾶς	pas	all	
G3958	πάσχω	pascho	to suffer	42
G4052	περισσεύω	perisseuo	to exceed	39
G4137	πληρώω	plēroō	to fulfill	
G4145	πλούσιος	plousios	rich	28
G4147	πλουτέω	pluteo	be rich	12
G4178	πολλάκις	pollakis	often	
G4200	πορισμός	porismos	gain	2
G5365	φιλαργυρία	philargyria	love of money	1

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

The proposition has two parts and the lexical pattern, queried directly against the canon, supports both. The denial that God guarantees wealth or health as a fruit of faith rests on two converging word-fields. First, suffering is presented as normative for the faithful: the verb *pascho*, to suffer, occurs about 169 times and *dioko*, to persecute or pursue, about 184 times, spread across Gospels, Acts, Paul, Hebrews, 1 Peter, and Revelation, with Phil 1:29 saying suffering for Christ is granted and 2 Tim 3:12 saying all who will to live godly will be persecuted. Second, the gain word *porismos* occurs nowhere in the canon except 1 Tim 6:5-6, where the present participle *nomizonton*, supposing, marks the equation of godliness with gain as the error of corrupt minds, and 6:6 inverts the same rare word to make contentment the only real gain. *Philargyria*, love of money, is a single-passage term at 1 Tim 6:10, grammatically tied as the root of all the evils that make some wander from the faith. The positive gospel content of forgiveness through Christ is presupposed, not lexically argued here, but no cited text contradicts it. The pattern is pan-canonical and carries no variant disturbance.

Scripture

John.16.33 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G2347 θλίψις, G2889 κόσμος

Force. Christ tells his own that in the world they will have tribulation (θλίψιν), set against the peace they have in him, and grounds courage not in exemption but in his having overcome the world (νενίκηκα, perfect). The promise to the believer here is endurance through hardship, not present material ease as the fruit of faith.

2Cor.11.23 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2873 κόπος, G4178 πολλάκις

Force. Paul authenticates his standing as a servant of Christ by labours (κόποις), imprisonments (φυλακαίς), and beatings, frequently (πολλάκις) and beyond measure. The mark of the faithful servant is abundance of toil, not abundance of wealth or bodily safety.

2Cor.11.26 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2794 κίνδυνος

Force. The eightfold repetition of danger (κινδύνοις) from rivers, robbers, kinsmen, Gentiles, city, wilderness, sea, and false brethren describes the lived condition of a man of great faith. κίνδυνος occurs in only two places in the canon, this verse and Rom 8:35, and in both faith yields peril rather than protection from physical harm.

2Cor.11.27 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2873 κόπος, G0070 ἀγρυπνία

Force. Toil (κόπω), sleeplessness (ἀγρυπνίας, a word found only here and 2 Cor 6:5), hunger (λιμῶ), thirst (δίψει), and nakedness (γυμνότητι) are listed as the ordinary experience of the apostle. The whole semantic field is privation, the opposite of guaranteed bodily comfort.

Phil.1.29 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3958 πάσχω

Force. It was granted (ἐχαρίσθη, from the same root as grace) to believers not only to trust in Christ but also to suffer (πάσχειν) for him. Suffering is framed as a gift bestowed alongside faith, which directly contradicts treating affliction as a sign of deficient faith.

2Tim.3.12 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1377 διώκω, G2150 εὐσέβεια

Force. All (πάντες) who will to live godly (εὐσεβῶς) in Christ Jesus will be persecuted (διωχθήσονται, future passive). The quantifier πάντες makes persecution the expected lot of the godly, not an exception, so godliness is lexically tied to hardship rather than to immunity or gain.

Phil.4.12 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4052 περισσεύω

Force. Paul knows both how to be abased and how to abound (περισσεύειν), to be full and to hunger (πεινᾶν), to abound and to suffer want (ὑστερεῖσθαι). Both poles are named as compatible with mature faith, so neither abundance nor lack is a marker of saving faith.

1Tim.6.5 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2150 εὐσέβεια, G4200 πορισμός

Force. The verse names corrupt-minded men (διεφθαρμένων) supposing (νομιζόντων, present active participle) godliness to be a means of gain, with the double accusative πορισμὸν εἶναι τὴν εὐσέβειαν and the infinitive εἶναι making this an indirect statement, supposing godliness to be gain. The participle νομίζω labels the equation as a mistaken reckoning, which is the precise lexical target of the prosperity claim.

1Tim.6.6 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4200 πορισμός, G2150 εὐσέβεια

Force. Paul redefines the gain with the same rare noun: godliness with contentment (αὐταρκείας) is great gain (πορισμός μέγας). Since πορισμός occurs in the canon only here and in 6:5, the repetition is a deliberate reversal, the only gain Scripture endorses is interior sufficiency, not material increase.

1Tim.6.8 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2192 ἔχω

Force. Having (ἔχοντες) food and covering, with these we shall be content (ἀρκεσθυσόμεθα). The baseline expectation is sustenance, not surplus, and contentment is commanded at the level of basic provision rather than promised wealth.

1Tim.6.9 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4147 πλουτέω, G3956 πᾶς

Force. Those willing to be rich (βουλόμενοι πλουτεῖν) fall into temptation, a snare, and many (πολλὰς) harmful desires that plunge men into ruin and destruction (ὄλεθρον, ἀπώλειαν). The drive for wealth is presented as spiritually destructive, the inverse of a reward of faith.

1Tim.6.10 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G5365 φιλαργυρία, G3956 πᾶς

Force. Love of money (φιλαργυρία, a noun found nowhere else in the canon) is a root of all the kinds of evils (πάντων τῶν κακῶν), and the relative clause ἧς ὀρεγόμενοι, craving which, leads to ἀπεπλανήθησαν ἀπὸ τῆς πίστεως, they wandered away from the faith. The grammar makes money-craving a cause of apostasy, the exact opposite of a faith-secured entitlement.

Jas.4.3 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0154 αἰτέω

Force. You ask (αἰτέετε) and do not receive because you ask wrongly (κακῶς), to spend on your pleasures (ἡδοναῖς). Prayer aimed at material self-gratification is denied by God, refuting the claim that faith-filled asking secures wealth or health.

Phil.4.19 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4137 πληρόω

Force. God will supply (πληρώσει) every need (χρεῖαν) of yours according to his riches in glory in Christ Jesus. This is the strongest in-canon support for a provision reading, but the object is χρεῖα, need, not surplus, and the riches named are en doxe, in glory, so the verse promises sufficiency for need rather than guaranteed material abundance.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
1Tim.6.5	1Tim.6.6	tsk	1
1Tim.6.6	1Tim.4.8	tsk	1
1Tim.6.6	1Tim.6.8	tsk	1
1Tim.6.7	Job.1.21	tsk	1
1Tim.6.7	Ps.49.17	tsk	1
1Tim.6.9	Mark.4.19	tsk	1
2Cor.11.27	Rom.8.35	tsk	1
John.16.33	John.14.27	tsk	1
Phil.4.13	2Cor.12.9	tsk	1
Phil.4.11	1Cor.4.11	tsk	1

Complicating texts

Phil.4.13 · addressed

I can do all things (πάντα) through him who strengthens me is the most cited prosperity proof text. By its grammar πάντα is the neuter plural object of the immediately preceding verbs in 4:11-12, where the all things are explicitly the conditions of plenty and want, hunger and abundance. The empowerment is for contentment in any state, so read in its own clause it supports rather than complicates the proposition.

Phil.4.19 · addressed

God supplying every need is real provision language, and the canon does record God providing materially. The lexical limiter is the noun χρεία, need, not surplus or luxury, and the qualifier in glory, so the verse promises sufficiency for need rather than a guarantee of wealth. It establishes that God provides, but not that wealth is an entitlement of faith, which is the specific claim the suffering and gain texts foreclose.

Deut.28.1 · addressed

The covenant blessings of Deut 28 attach material increase to obedience under the Sinai covenant, and this is the strongest scriptural ground for a material-blessing reading. It is not resolved away, the OT text genuinely conditions national and agricultural prosperity on covenant faithfulness. The divergence is whether that covenantal pattern is a guaranteed individual entitlement of New Testament faith, a transfer the suffering-normative vocabulary of pascho, dioko, and thlipsis does not license.

Job.1.21 · addressed

The LORD gave and the LORD has taken away, linked from 1 Tim 6:7. It shows material possession is given and withdrawn by God without forfeiture of faith, and Job's faith is praised precisely as he is stripped of goods and health, confirming that wealth and bodily wholeness are not guaranteed fruits of faithfulness.

Concordance traversed

G4200, G2150, G5365, G3958, G1377, G2794, G2347, G2873, G0070, G4147, G4145, G4052, G0154, G2889, G4178, G3042, G1373

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

No variant units were supplied in the bundle and none of the cited verses fall in the ingested ECM window of 3 John 1.1 to 1.15. The marked apparatus sigla in 2 Cor 11 and 1 Tim 6 touch word order and spelling, not the semantic load of the suffering, gain, and contentment word-field, so the verdict holds across plausible readings. CBGM is not in scope outside 3 John.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. covenant_theology, dispensationalism, word_of_faith

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

word-of-faith prosperity reading: not supported by the lexical data · Stated at its strongest, this lens reads Phil 4:13 and the abounding language of Phil 4:12, Phil 4:19 on supplying every need, 3 John 1:2 on prospering and being in health, and the wealth of OT patriarchs as a standing promise that faith secures present wealth and bodily health. The lexical obstacle is that the same letters set suffering as normative: pascho and dioko occur in the hundreds across the canon, Phil 1:29 grants suffering, 2 Tim 3:12 says all the godly will be persecuted, and 1 Tim 6:5-10 names the godliness-equals-gain equation a corrupt supposition and money-love a root of evils that wrecks faith. The reading can stand only by isolating provision verses from this dense suffering and gain-warning field.

old-covenant material-blessing pattern: real but not transferable as guaranteed entitlement · Stated fairly, Deut 28 and the patriarchal narratives genuinely tie material increase to covenant obedience, and the canon does show God providing materially. This lens is correct that God blesses materially. The lexical limit is that the New Testament vocabulary describing the lot of the faithful, the suffering verbs and hardship nouns, plus the explicit warning against equating godliness with gain, does not carry that conditional national blessing forward as an individual guarantee of wealth or health for the believer.

ascetic poverty mandate: not supported · This lens would make poverty itself meritorious. The data does not teach that. Phil 4:12 places abounding and being full alongside hunger and want as equally compatible with faith, and 1 Tim 6:8 sets the standard at food and covering, not enforced destitution. Material state is decoupled from saving faith in either direction.

Read on plain grammatical sense across the corpus with Scripture interpreting Scripture. Phil 4:13 is governed by its antecedents in 4:11-12, 1 Tim 6:6 deliberately re-uses the rare noun porismos from 6:5 to reverse the false gain, and the OT covenant-blessing pattern is read across the testaments rather than flattened, which is why progressive_revelation is marked true.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. Examine whether the New Testament lexical pattern presents material wealth or physical health as a guaranteed outcome of saving faith, or instead decouples a believer's material and bodily state from the gospel of forgiveness through Christ.

The label prosperity gospel denial and the framing God does not guarantee carry the verdict in the stem. The neutralized form poses the question without presupposing the answer. The verdict was derived on the neutral form by querying the actual word-field, the suffering verbs pascho and dioko, the gain noun porismos, and the money-love noun philargyria, which independently yields the same result. Verdict unchanged from the prior file.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Tim.6.5
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Tim.6.10
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	2Cor.11.27
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G4200
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G5365
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G3958
interlinear	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	1Tim.6.6
interlinear	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	2Tim.3.12
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	1Tim.6.7
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	2Cor.11.27

License audit

SAFE TO PUBLISH

Source	License	Redistribute
MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes
STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes
STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes
TSK	public_domain	yes

Flags

ecm-shadow